CHAPTER THREE

The Colours of Heraldry

EVEN THE most casual observer may be struck with delight by a bold and colourful heraldic display and it is important from the outset to discuss the Heraldic colours and the ways in which they are used.

The student will soon become aware that the colours of Heraldry are in fact few; it is by skilful combinations of them that bold effects are produced. The colours, or tinctures, as they are properly called, must always be of the clearest and purest tone possible to give a bold, brilliant and unambiguous effect. They were originally chosen so that the wearer would be readily identifiable at a distance, and in the 'pell-mell' of battle, and their bold and striking combination is a vital part of the continuing tradition.

The tinctures fall into three groups: (1) those that represent metals; (2) those that represent colours; and (3) those that represent furs.

Those That Represent Metal

The tincture white represents silver and is called 'argent', abbreviated 'ar'. The tincture yellow represents gold and is called 'or'.

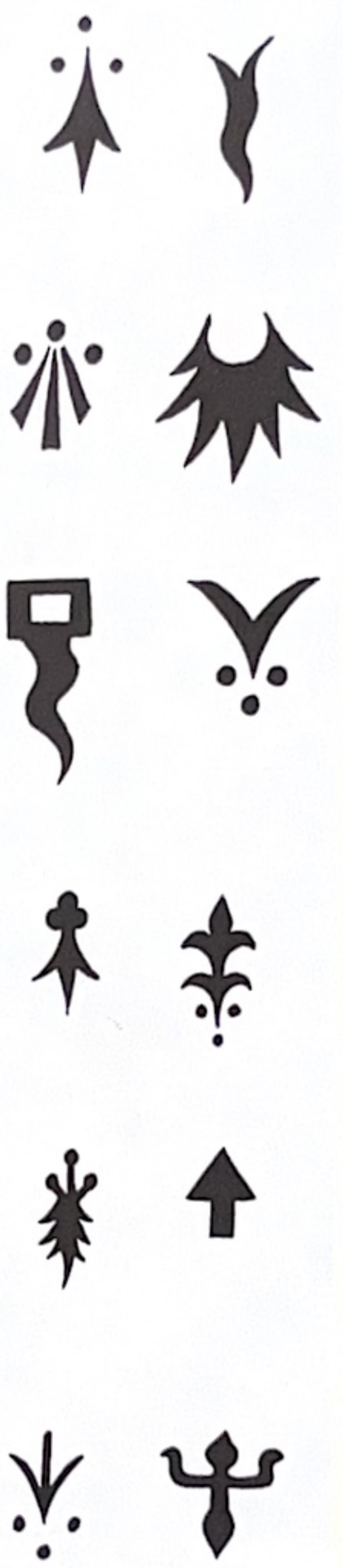
It is quite proper to use silver or gold paint, but because of the difficulty of finding suitable pigments that will not blacken with age, it has become the custom to paint these tinctures with yellow and white. In very important documents it is customary to use gold or silver leaf on those parts that should be of these colours.

Those That Represent Colours

These are listed below, each with its Heraldic term and usual abbreviation. When a Coat of Arms is drawn in black and white, it is necessary to indicate what the tinctures are; a scheme of shading to use for each tincture (which is also shown), has therefore been developed.

There was at one time a custom of describing the colours used by the planets and precious stones and metals. Because examples of this practice may still be found, they are set out in the table below. The colours are red, blue, green, black and purple.

There have been introduced in more recent times the following shades, or stains, as they are called — orange, blood red, mulberry purple and sky blue. Their use is not widespread, although sky blue, as opposed to the true royal blue normally used, is being introduced especially by people connected with aviation and space exploration.



Many designs, of which a number are shown here, have been devised to represent ermine in Heraldry. Each is a representation of the animal's tail.

Those That Represent Furs

Because of the importance of fur and its common use in contemporary dress, colours and patterns have been devised to represent fur in Heraldry. The use of fur in a variety of forms is common in Heraldry, though it does not necessarily indicate any special rank.

Ermine The fur most commonly found is ermine, in its several forms. In northern climates the common stoat, a fierce, small, predatory animal, normally coloured a sandy chestnut, changes its coat to pure white in the winter, but for the tip of the tail, which remains black. Ermine furs were highly prized and, because of their relative rarity and because of the large number of them needed, for example, to line a royal cloak, they were extremely expensive. They were sewn together, still with the tail attached, which hung loose. The Heraldic representation of ermine is white, strewn with a regular black pattern representing the tails. A large number of designs have been recorded in Heraldic representation of these tails.

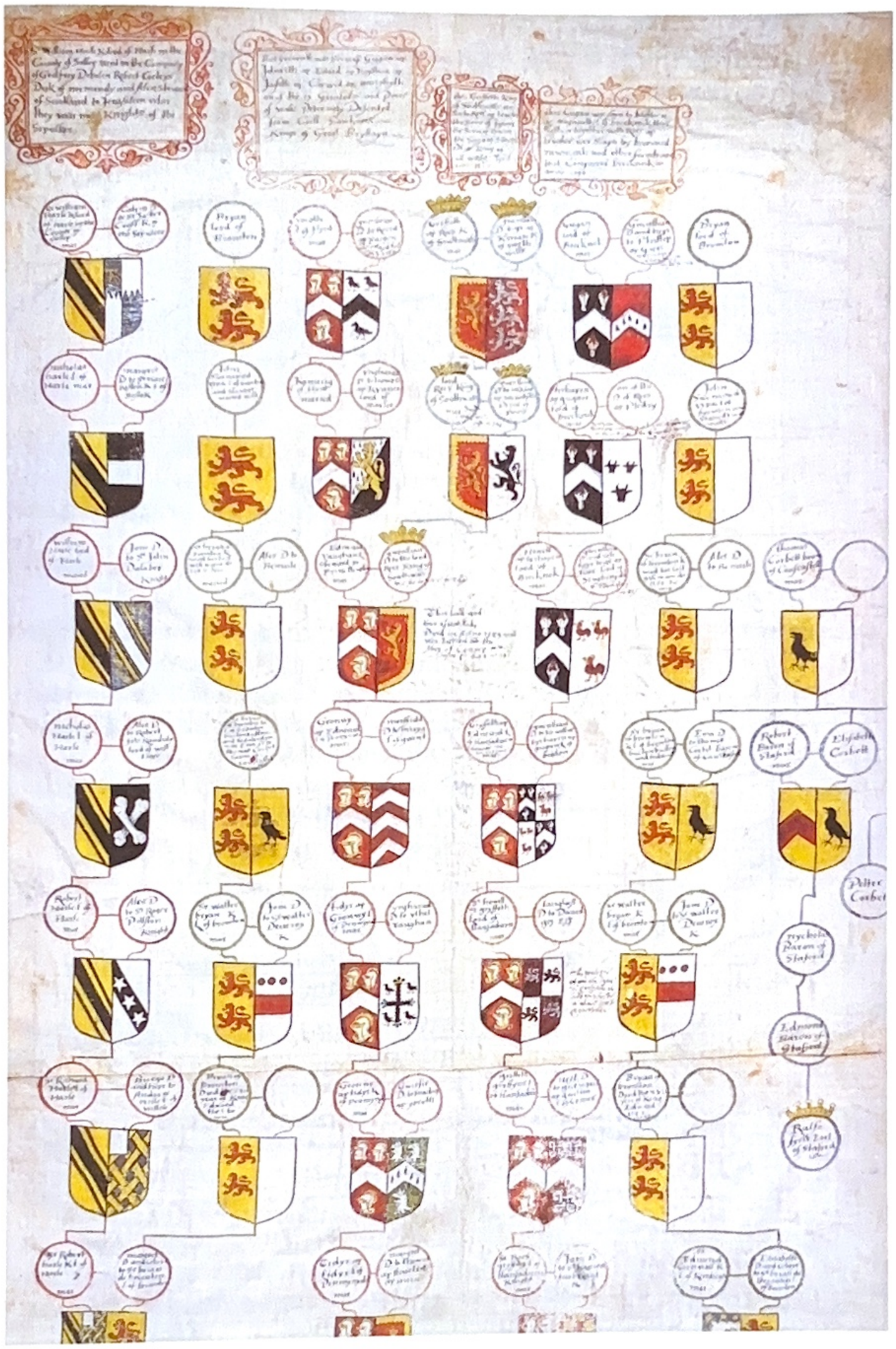
Various combinations are also used, each with its own name:

ERMINE	White with black tails
ERMINOIS	Gold with black tails
ERMINES	Black with white tails
PEAN	Black with gold tails

Vair (or Vaire, Vairy, Verre, Verrey, Verry) The next most common fur is vair, in a variety of forms. It is always drawn as an alternating pattern of rounded or angular pieces of different colours. It is said by contemporary writers to represent the skins of the grey squirrel, sewn belly to back alternately, thus producing the white and blue pattern. Vair is always blue and white, unless other colours are specified, in which case the first colour mentioned is always the piece in the top dexter corner. Vair is met in a variety of forms and these are shown below. A vair pattern of colours other than blue and white is always described as being 'vairy of' whatever the colours specified. The most common forms of vair are vair, counter-vair, potent, counter-potent, vair ancient, and vary.

Diapering

When the Christian knights returned from the Crusades they brought back with them fantastic brocades, woven materials and silks that they discovered in the sophisticated and civilized (compared to their own more robust environment) society that they encountered around the shores of the eastern Mediterranean. Cere-



The 16th century armorial family tree of Anne Hale; note the use of the colours yellow and white in place of gold and silver.